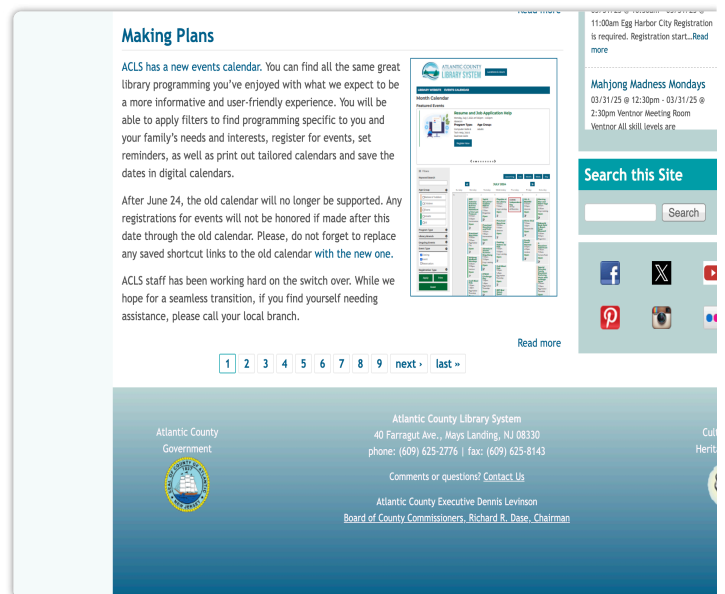


Rethinking the county library system

Identifying and fixing problems with website usability and learnability



Growing up in Atlantic County, I visited [this website](#) weekly to check for book availability and local events, but I often struggled to navigate it and often left the site frustrated. Some of the main issues I noticed are detailed below.

Website Efficiency

The two search bars are initially hard to see and can be confused with each other. It's hard to understand the goal of the website: searching the book catalog and finding local events.

There is a lot of information initially presented on the screen, which can be overwhelming for users and can distract users finding what they need.

There are repetitive elements, like text and the multiple "Upcoming Events" sections.

Website Learnability

Again, the amount of text and components the user is presented with can make it hard for them to digest the information, making the website hard to learn.

Personally, I visited the website many times before I realized there is a search bar available to browse the website. This is because it is hidden away at the bottom of the screen.

Website Memorability

The website is not memorable at all. The color scheme, while nice, is pretty neutral. There is nothing setting this site apart.

Website's Conceptual Model

Overall, the amount of information is very overwhelming, which makes it difficult for users to understand the conceptual model of the website.

The lack of clear hierarchy and organization of information makes it difficult for users to understand how to navigate the site.

Main Issues with Website Accessibility

WAVE Web Accessibility Evaluation Tools found 21 errors, 75 alerts, and 8 contrast errors with the site

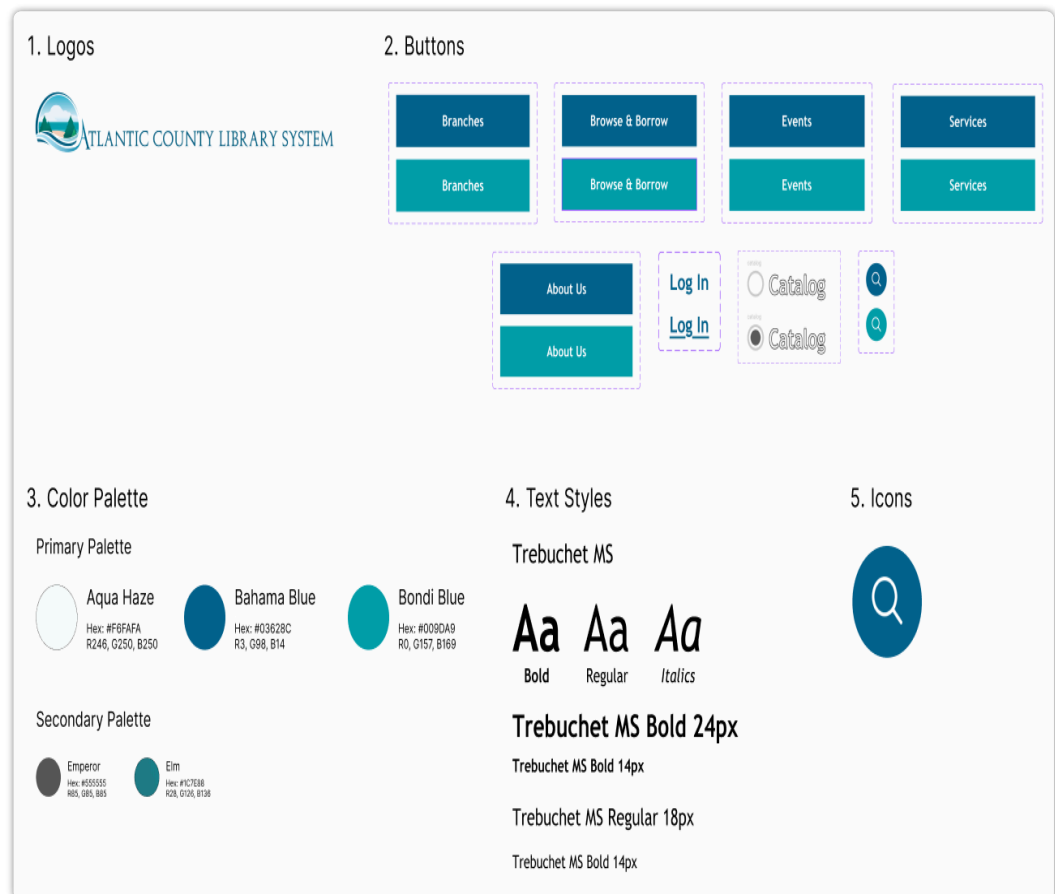
Most alerts were about empty links, redundant titles and text, and many images and titles missing alternative text.

Taking these issues into account, I started redesigning the library website starting with a...

Visual Design Style Guide

This visual design style guide displays the main colors, typography, and reusable components' different states (buttons on hover, click, etc.). The clear documentation shows the consistency of the design work and makes handoffs to other members on a team easier.

To see these components and new ideas in action, I next created three (Large Computer, Tablet, and Phone) figma mockups on what the site will look like. These mockups are annotated with the new changes I made and how developers would go about recreating these design choices.



Large Computer

Developer Element Guide

Header Container:
display: flex, align-items: baseline

Log In Button: margin-left: auto

Navigation Bar: flex container, padding: 0px 105px, align-items: center, line-height: 50px

Search Bar Container:
display: flex; flex-direction: column; align-items: center; gap: 10px;

Radio Buttons: display: flex; gap: 15px;

Main Image Container:
display: flex; flex-direction: column; align-items: center; justify-content: center;

Footer: padding: 20px 0px; text-align: center;

The logo now links back to the home page, reducing the need for a "Home" header. This feature is typical in websites, which allows for easy learnability and removes repetitive components.

The original color scheme, logo, and font were maintained to give users a sense of familiarity the the new website.

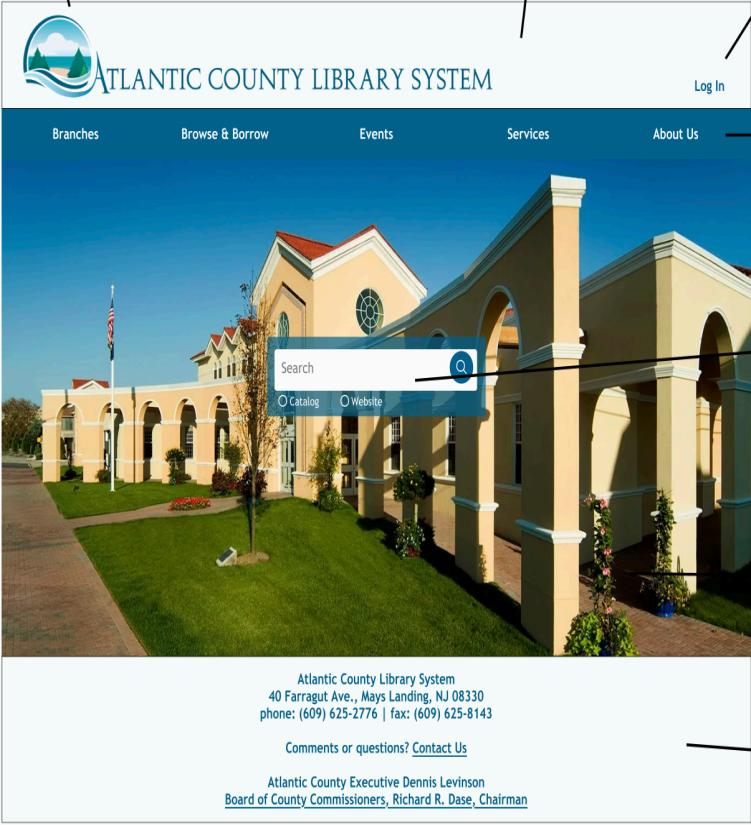
A front and center "Log In" button has been added for patrons who are visiting the site to check on book holds or event reservations.

The dropdown menu names have been reorganized to be less repetitive and more representative of the site's information.

The two search bars have been combined into one and are displayed front and center to avoid any confusion. The radio buttons allow users to toggle in between searching the website or the catalog.

The home page has been removed of any excess text and articles, which have been moved to a different page. The main goal of the homepage is to not be too overwhelming and allow users to easily orient themselves.

A footer very similar to the original with contact information is at the bottom of the home page for users to easily access.



As the screen size decreases, the searchbar component becomes focal point of page.

Tablet

Phone

The logo now links back to the home page, reducing the need for a "Home" header. This feature is typical in websites, which allows for easy learnability and removes repetitive components.

The original color scheme, logo, and font were maintained to give users a sense of familiarity the the new website.

A front and center "Log In" button has been added for patrons who are visiting the site to check on book holds or event reservations.

The dropdown menu names have been reorganized to be less repetitive and more representative of the site's information.

The two search bars have been combined into one and are displayed front and center to avoid any confusion. The radio buttons allow users to toggle in between searching the website or the catalog.

Developer Element Guide

Header Container: display: flex; align-items: baseline

Log In Button: margin-left: auto

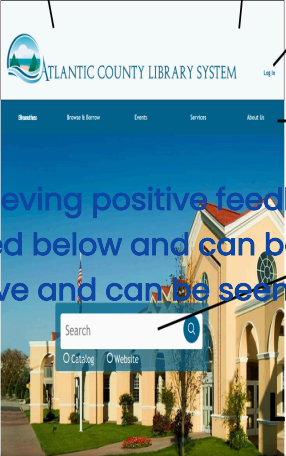
Navigation Bar: flex container; padding: 10px; align-items: center; line-height: 1

Search Bar Container: display: flex; flex-direction: column; align-items: center;

Radio Buttons: display: flex; gap: 10px;

Main Image Container: display: flex; flex-direction: column; align-items: center; justify-content: center;

Footer: padding: 20px; text-align: center;



The logo now links back to the home page, reducing the need for a "Home" header. This feature is typical in websites, which allows for easy learnability and removes repetitive components.

The original color scheme, logo, and font were maintained to give users a sense of familiarity the the new website.

A front and center "Log In" button has been added for patrons who are visiting the site to check on book holds or event reservations.

Due to the limited space, the dropdown menu has been moved to be out of sight initially. This way, the screen is less cluttered and not overwhelming.

The two search bars have been combined into one and are displayed front and center to avoid any confusion. The radio buttons allow users to toggle in between searching the website or the catalog.

The home page has been removed of any excess text and clutter. The main goal is to not be too cluttered and allow users to find what they need.

Developer Element Guide

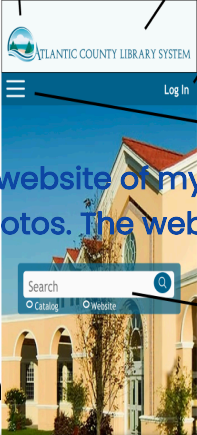
Header Container: display: flex; align-items: baseline

Log In Button: margin-left: auto

Search Bar Container: display: flex; flex-direction: column; align-items: center;

Radio Buttons: display: flex; flex-direction: column; align-items: center; justify-content: center;

Footer: padding: 20px; text-align: center;



After receiving positive feedback from my peers, I created a website of my design, which is pictured below and can be accessed by clicking on the photos. The website is very responsive and can be seen in three different screen sizes.

Large Computer Redesign



Tablet Redesign

Phone Redesign

